

Proposal: reduce per-group allocation in `_build_protein_rollup`

branch `perf/alloc-diagnostics`

2026-06-24

1 Summary

`_build_protein_rollup` (in `src/Routines/SearchDIA/SearchMethods/ProteinScoringSearch/protein_infer`) is called **once per protein group** inside two `groupby` loops. Each call allocates **14 Dicts plus several row vectors**; over all groups $\times$ files this is ~ 0.6 GB on the YeastStandard3M benchmark (the largest single site in the Protein Scoring phase, which totals 1.98 GB).

The fix is to (a) replace the 14 Dicts with **3 dedup Dicts + reusable parallel arrays**, and (b) hoist that scratch out of the per-group function so it is **allocated once and reused** across groups. Net per-group allocation drops from “14 Dicts + vectors” to “the returned output rows only”.

Caveat (please note): the current function emits its rows in Dict-hash iteration order, and `pg_score` is an *order-sensitive* `Float32` sum (§4). The new design iterates in deterministic first-seen order instead, so this is a **deliberate, one-time protein-scoring rebaseline** (a few protein groups may shift, same class as the approved iRT-refinement rebaseline). It also *removes* the latent order-fragility permanently. Verification plan in §8.

2 Where it is called (per protein group)

Loop 1 — `protein_inference_pipeline.jl:664--666`:

```
664 for gdf in groupby(df, [:inferred_protein_group, :target, :entrap_id])
665     quant_mask = _protein_rollup_quant_mask(gdf; q_value_threshold = q_value_threshold)
666     rollup = _build_protein_rollup(gdf, quant_mask, prob_col)
```

Loop 2 — `:1124--1126` (inside `combine(grouped) do gdf ... end`):

```
1124 protein_groups = combine(grouped) do gdf
1125     quant_mask = _protein_rollup_quant_mask(gdf; q_value_threshold = q_value_threshold)
1126     rollup = _build_protein_rollup(gdf, quant_mask, prob_col)
```

Both call once per (`inferred_protein_group`, `target`, `entrap_id`) group, for each run/file. Both loops are sequential (a plain `for`, and DataFrames `combine`, which is single-threaded), so a single reusable scratch instance per loop is safe.

3 Current implementation (the 14 Dicts)

Per-precursor level — **7 Dicts** (`:427--459`)

```

427 prob_by_precursor      = Dict{UInt32, Float32}()
428 best_peak_area_by_precursor = Dict{UInt32, Float32}()
429 base_pep_id_by_precursor  = Dict{UInt32, UInt32}()
430 sequence_by_precursor     = Dict{UInt32, String}()
431 charge_by_precursor       = Dict{UInt32, UInt8}()
432 structural_mods_by_precursor = Dict{UInt32, String}()
433 isotopic_mods_by_precursor  = Dict{UInt32, String}()
434
435 @inbounds for i in eachindex(quant_mask)
436     quant_mask[i] || continue
437     precursor_idx = UInt32(gdf.precursor_idx[i])
438     prob_val      = _sanitize_rollup_probability(gdf[!, prob_col][i])
439     peak_area_val = Float32(gdf.peak_area[i])
440     if haskey(prob_by_precursor, precursor_idx)
441         prob_by_precursor[precursor_idx] = max(prob_by_precursor[precursor_idx], prob_val)
442         if peak_area_val > best_peak_area_by_precursor[precursor_idx]
443             best_peak_area_by_precursor[precursor_idx] = peak_area_val
444         end
445     else
446         prob_by_precursor[precursor_idx]      = prob_val
447         best_peak_area_by_precursor[precursor_idx] = peak_area_val
448         base_pep_id_by_precursor[precursor_idx] = UInt32(gdf.base_pep_id[i])
449         sequence_by_precursor[precursor_idx]    = String(gdf.sequence[i])
450         charge_by_precursor[precursor_idx]      = hasproperty(gdf, :charge) ? UInt8(gdf.charge[i]) : UInt8(0)
451         structural_mods_by_precursor[precursor_idx] = ... # String or ""
452         isotopic_mods_by_precursor[precursor_idx]  = ... # String or ""
453     end
454 end

```

The output rows are then built by iterating keys(prob_by_precursor) (:463) — i.e. in Dict-hash order.

Per-modified-peptide level — 4 Dicts (:493--496)

```

493 modified_log_none_sum = Dict{Tuple{UInt32, String, String}, Float64}()
494 modified_best_peak_area = Dict{Tuple{UInt32, String, String}, Float32}()
495 modified_sequence      = Dict{Tuple{UInt32, String, String}, String}()
496 modified_precursor_count = Dict{Tuple{UInt32, String, String}, Int32}()

```

Per-peptide level — 3 Dicts (:529--531)

```

529 peptide_log_none_sum = Dict{String, Float64}()
530 peptide_best_peak_area = Dict{String, Float32}()
531 peptide_modified_count = Dict{String, Int32}()

```

Total: $7 + 4 + 3 = 14$ Dicts allocated per call. Measured contribution (Profile.Allocs, sampled): ~ 0.6 GB across lines 438–540.

4 The order fragility

pg_score is a Float32 sum over peptide_rows (:556):

```

556 pg_score = isempty(peptide_rows) ? 0.0f0 : Float32(sum(row.score for row in peptide_rows))

```

peptide_rows is built by iterating `keys(peptide_log_none_sum)` (:545), i.e. Dict-hash order. Floating-point summation is not associative, so the iteration order changes `pg_score` in the last bits. `pg_score` feeds protein-group FDR, so a last-bit change can flip a borderline protein near the q-value threshold. *This is why naive scratch reuse (empty! changes a Dict's capacity, hence its iteration order) is not byte-for-byte result-neutral* — the same mechanism as the iRT `sizehint!` issue. (`peptide_list` at :558 is `sort!`'d so it is already order-independent; `top_pep_peak_area` is a maximum, also fine.)

5 Why not merge the Dicts into one struct-valued Dict?

A natural idea is `Dict{UInt32, PrecAccum}`. It does not help: the per-precursor record holds `String` fields (`sequence`, `structural_mods`, `isotopic_mods`), so `PrecAccum` is not `isbits` and the Dict would box one struct *per precursor* — worse than 7 scalar/String Dicts.

6 Proposed change

Use **one dedup Dict per level** (`precursor_idx` / `mod-key` / `sequence` → a row index) plus **parallel arrays** for the fields, pushed in **first-seen order**. Iterate the arrays by position (deterministic, capacity-independent). Hold all of this in a `ProteinRollupScratch` that the caller allocates once and passes in; `_reset!` it (empty! the 3 Dicts + the arrays, keeping their capacity) at the start of each call.

Scratch type (allocated once per loop, reused)

```

1 mutable struct ProteinRollupScratch
2     # precursor level (dedup by precursor_idx; parallel arrays, first-seen order)
3     prec_pos      :: Dict{UInt32, Int}
4     prec_id       :: Vector{UInt32}
5     prec_prob     :: Vector{Float32}
6     prec_peak     :: Vector{Float32}
7     prec_basepep  :: Vector{UInt32}
8     prec_seq      :: Vector{String}
9     prec_charge   :: Vector{UInt8}
10    prec_smods    :: Vector{String}
11    prec_imods     :: Vector{String}
12    # modified-peptide level (dedup by (base_pep_id, structural_mods, isotopic_mods))
13    mod_pos       :: Dict{Tuple{UInt32,String,String}, Int}
14    mod_key       :: Vector{Tuple{UInt32,String,String}}
15    mod_logsum    :: Vector{Float64}
16    mod_peak      :: Vector{Float32}
17    mod_seq       :: Vector{String}
18    mod_count     :: Vector{Int32}
19    # peptide level (dedup by sequence)
20    pep_pos       :: Dict{String, Int}
21    pep_seq       :: Vector{String}
22    pep_logsum    :: Vector{Float64}
23    pep_peak      :: Vector{Float32}
24    pep_count     :: Vector{Int32}
25 end

```

Per-precursor accumulation (replaces :427–459)

```
1 _reset!(s) # empty! the 3 Dicts and all arrays (capacity retained for reuse)
2 @inbounds for i in eachindex(quant_mask)
3     quant_mask[i] || continue
4     pid      = UInt32(gdf.precursor_idx[i])
5     prob_val  = _sanitize_rollup_probability(gdf[:, prob_col][i])
6     peak_val  = Float32(gdf.peak_area[i])
7     pos = get(s.prec_pos, pid, 0)
8     if pos == 0 # first time we see this precursor
9         push!(s.prec_id, pid)
10        push!(s.prec_prob, prob_val)
11        push!(s.prec_peak, peak_val)
12        push!(s.prec_basepep, UInt32(gdf.base_pep_idx[i]))
13        push!(s.prec_seq, String(gdf.sequence[i]))
14        push!(s.prec_charge, hasproperty(gdf, :charge) ? UInt8(gdf.charge[i]) : UInt8(0))
15        push!(s.prec_smods, _mods_or_empty(gdf, :structural_mods, i))
16        push!(s.prec_imods, _mods_or_empty(gdf, :isotopic_mods, i))
17        s.prec_pos[pid] = length(s.prec_id) # row index in the parallel arrays
18    else # seen before: update aggregates only
19        s.prec_prob[pos] = max(s.prec_prob[pos], prob_val)
20        if peak_val > s.prec_peak[pos]; s.prec_peak[pos] = peak_val; end
21    end
22 end
23 # build precursor_rows by iterating 1:length(s.prec_id) (first-seen order)
```

The modified-peptide and peptide levels follow the identical pattern (one dedup Dict + parallel arrays each). The returned `precursor_rows` / `modified_peptide_rows` / `peptide_rows` are still built (they are the output the callers consume) — only the *intermediate* 14 Dicts become 3 reused dedup Dicts + reused arrays.

Caller change (allocate scratch once)

```
1 scratch = ProteinRollupScratch() # once, before the loop
2 for gdf in groupby(df, [...])
3     quant_mask = _protein_rollup_quant_mask(gdf; ...)
4     rollup = _build_protein_rollup(gdf, quant_mask, prob_col, scratch) # 4-arg
5 end
```

A 3-arg method `_build_protein_rollup(gdf, quant_mask, prob_col)` is kept (allocates a fresh scratch then calls the 4-arg form) so the existing signature and any tests keep working.

7 Allocation impact (expected)

Per group: **14 Dict allocations** → **0** (3 dedup Dicts + 14 arrays all reused from the scratch). The only remaining per-group allocations are the returned output row vectors (necessary). Expected saving on YeastStandard3M: ~0.3–0.5 GB of the 0.6 GB (to be confirmed by the `@alloc_bucket/Profile.Allocs` re-run).

8 Correctness, rebaseline, and verification

- **Aggregates unchanged:** max/sum/count per precursor/peptide are identical regardless of iteration order; only the *order* in which rows are emitted changes (Dict-hash → first-seen).

- **Deliberate rebaseline:** because `pg_score` sums in row order, the new first-seen order changes `pg_score` in the last bits, so a few borderline protein groups may cross the FDR threshold. This is a one-time rebaseline (and removes the latent order-fragility for good — the result becomes a deterministic function of the input, not of Dict capacity).
- **Verification:** fresh-process determinism (the new protein-group / precursor counts must be *reproducible* across runs); confirm the change vs the current baseline is small (1 %, like the iRT rebaseline) — a large change would signal a bug. Re-run `@alloc_bucket / Profile.Allocs` to confirm the allocation drop and no Protein Scoring time regression. Existing ProteinScoringSearch unit tests must pass.

9 Optional follow-on (not in this change)

The returned `*_rows Vector{NamedTuple}` are still allocated per group. If the callers consumed the scratch parallel arrays directly, those could be avoided too — but that touches the caller contract and is left out to keep this change focused.